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Joseph Daley

Low brass player and composer Joseph Daley pays tribute to and expands upon the vital music pioneered by Sam Rivers and other creative artists of the 1970s. Joseph has contributed to New York City music culture as an educator, sideman and leader of groups such as the Earth Tones Ensemble, the Ebony Brass Quintet and the Joseph Daley Tuba Trio.

Joseph was interviewed in Utica, New York on March 18, 2018 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

JD: We're at The Other Side.

MR: The Other Side, yes.

JD: The Other side.

MR: In Utica. My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Joseph Daley with me today. Welcome.

JD: It's a pleasure to be here, and thank you very much for this opportunity. I'm looking forward to it.

MR: You are seeing a bit of the New York State Thruway this week.

JD: Yeah, we're going back and forth to some interesting spots you know, in Syracuse and Buffalo and Utica, and now we're heading to the Bop Shop, which has been giving music for quite a long time, they've been doing music for at least, I think at least twenty years he's been doing music in Rochester.

MR: Yeah.

JD: And he's like an institution. Just about every band that's on the road, they kind of go in and pay homage to him, you know, for what he does.

MR: It's interesting because it's sort of re-creating the way things were in the 60s around here, from what I was told, the jazz musicians from New York would make a little pilgrimage and they could play Albany, Utica, Syracuse, Rochester, Buffalo and back.

JD: Oh yeah. Well that's possible again because, Internet now. You can get on the Internet and see where the clubs are or who is producing music, and you could actually get in touch with them, you know, via Facebook. So it makes it possible. And musicians, via the Internet and other social media have developed a whole different type of booking procedure. Now they can book themselves directly with the owners of the venues, rather than going through an agent.

MR: Right. Last night we played in this space, I can see the tympani behind you.

JD: Yeah, tremendously played by Warren Smith, one of the great tympanists.

MR: It's interesting because at some point I was, while you were playing, I was, on occasion I'd close my eyes and just do the ear thing. And I was hearing these sounds, like is that coming from the tympani?

JD: Yeah. Warren makes the tympani — well he plays the tympani through the African tradition of the talking drum. It's a European instrument but he incorporates a lot of African-American elements into it. You know, the moans and the groans and the talking drum. You know, the African talking drum elements of pitches up and down and everything. So he actually makes the tympani talk. You hear verbal things that the tympani says. He just doesn't play it as an instrument. He plays it as an extension of his voice.

MR: I'm glad you said that. Because it's exactly what I felt I was hearing from you.

JD: Oh yeah.

MR: Especially when you played the euphonium.

JD: The euphonium yeah.

MR: I just felt like this instrument is directly connected to your inner being.

JD: Yeah well my singing voice is in the same range as the euphonium, and the euphonium is one of those instruments that really really sings out and everything. So when I play, my stylistic way of playing it is to make the instrument really really sing out like a human voice. Similar to people like Paul Robeson and those are the kind of people I kind of emulate when I'm trying to play the instrument. So I don't really play that as an instrument, similar to Warren, you know I kind of just play it as an extension of my voice and everything. So it gives it a different type of articulation.

MR: Can you remember when you were in let's say your early teens. What was the music that you would have bought LPs for?

JD: Junior high school or high school?

MR: Maybe junior high.

JD: Well junior high school, you know, Motown records were very very popular then so it would be some selection of Motown. And then I grew up in the lower east side of Manhattan and Latin music was very popular so you know the music of Tito Puente, you know, those type of, Eddie Palmieri and everything. I would definitely participate. And then my family is from the Caribbean. My parents came from Montserrat British West Indies, so we always had a lot of calypsos and those types of music from the Caribbean too. So it was a combination of Caribbean music, you know, Latin music that surrounded me in the neighborhood that I grew up in, and then popular music and everything. Unfortunately at that age I was not listening to jazz. I didn't get into jazz until high school. You know so, and my parents were not into jazz either. So they listen. My

Episcopalian so it wasn't the Gospel music, but the anthem, the Anglican anthems. We mainly sang those type of things, is the kind of music that my parents listened to.

MR: When you were in church singing those hymns, do you remember what might have been going through your head as far as, I'm not sure how to phrase this question, were you wanting to move away from the written note?

JD: No. No. In an Episcopalian upbringing, no. My mind was you better not move away from that, no. My mother was not a big fan of Gospel music. She thought it was, you know, because you've got to realize that you know, Montserrat was colonized by the British. And they, you know the British are very very strict and stern and most western music came out of islands that were colonized from the British were very very conservative and in church you sang the hymn like it was written. You did not venture forth or move away from any, or bend a note or any type of thing. And the structure harmonically was four part harmony similar to the chorales of Bach, you know, four part harmony, Bach. Bach chorales and other things that were used to harmonize the different melodies that we sang.

MR: Were you attracted to the bass clef at that point? I'm trying to figure out what brought you to the tuba.

JD: My evolution into the tuba is that when I was very young, in elementary school they started a band program in my elementary school. And I brought the notice home to my mother and she was very excited. And so she signed me up for it, and I started, you know, so in those days you started as a class. You started as a band class. I started in the band class where you have clarinets, trumpets, trombones and everything in the class. Everybody learned at the same time. It's not like I went out for a private instruction lesson. So everybody learned at the same time. So in those days what they did was they determined maybe your arm length, your lip size, and your body size to determine what instrument they choose so they can balance out the band. So he thought my arms were long enough to be able to manipulate a trombone, and my lips were a good size, they could, you know, really fit into a trombone mouthpiece. So my initial band director started me on the trombone, which I like tremendously. And then my mother, she really wanted me to excel so down on the lower east side of Manhattan there was a historical music school called the Henry Street Settlement. It's been there for decades and everything. And they offered scholarships. So my mother brought me down and filled out the scholarship forms and they gave me — just based on financial need and everything. So I got a scholarship to study theory and trombone. And so because of that I began to excel and I became a really fine trombone player by the time I got through junior high school. And the junior high school band I entered into, the band director was Howard

instrument: bassoons, trombones, trumpets, tubas you name it. Full clarinet section. And he played trumpet himself and then every day he'd have the band play [scats]. And the way he got us to want to do that is one of the first lessons he did, he would just take out the trumpet. He went [scats]. And that sounded so good that everybody wanted to be able to do it. So every rehearsal we'd start, right through the keys. He would have a different key. So we'd go like through all twelve keys. By the end of the year we got through [scats], and then the chromatic scale [scats]. So you know it was a tremendous, tremendous band mainly because of the director and the inspiration. So he really inspired me. So I became a really fine — I was playing first trombone and he came over to me one day and he says, "Listen, you know, you're a really really fine trombonist and I need somebody to move into the tuba section because we're short there. We're slightly off balance and we need to add another tuba into the section." So you know you could imagine the admiration I had for this man, his brilliant playing and his brilliant way of teaching a class, so anything that he would say — I would have probably done it. So anyway I said sure you know. So I put the trombone down and he brought me in for a couple of days, just to get me oriented with the tuba and everything. And then I just took to it. It just became a natural thing. I just took to it. And the tuba became my voice at a very, very early age. And I just progressed so fast that within a month or so he was able to place me, in New York at that time they had borough-wide bands where the best students from all the boroughs would go, like Manhattan had theirs, Queens had theirs, you know, the Bronx had theirs. So I was placed into the Manhattan borough-wide band. And I did exceptionally well there in the band. And I progressed until they moved me into the orchestra. The orchestra was for really select brass players. Because the orchestra, you know, mainly the orchestra would just work with strings and then they would bring the brass and the woodwinds in towards the end. So you'd have to be a good reader.

MR: You were like one on a part, too.

JD: Yeah. Definitely one on a part. So I moved into the orchestra setting at the junior high school level. And then I carried that up. And when I graduated from junior high school I went to a very very prestigious high school in New York called Music and Art High School. Music and Art High School is known because of the sister school called Performing Arts. That movie "Fame" was based on Performing Arts. But Music and Art and Performing Arts were like sister schools or brother schools, depending on your perspective. So I was surrounded at that particular point, you know, with these very very creative young people and very creative and talented musicians and everything. And my tuba playing at that particular time, you know, got really profound. Because you know I

All-City High School Orchestra, which was the most prestigious orchestra in New York at that time for high school students. So he was like the tubist in that orchestra. So I just followed him around. And every time he practiced I'd practice and then I became very very proficient.

MR: When did you get your own tuba?

JD: Oh yeah well that's a very interesting story. I borrowed tubas until I graduated from college. I just didn't have the financial means to buy an instrument. So many band directors, they realized that I couldn't, so they would just like lend me the tuba and said I can use it until, as long as I returned it when I was done. And what happened, when I graduated from college, my mother, unbeknownst to me, she was, all this time she would just say, because that's the way, my mother was one of those people that she would just save money. She'd put a penny here, a dollar there. So all through this period my mother was saving money, saving money, saving money, until when I graduated from college she had enough money that she gave me the payment to be able to buy my first, because I bought my first tuba after I graduated from college at Manhattan School of Music nonetheless.

MR: Logistically I just think of you like carting a tuba home on the school bus or whatever.

JD: Oh yeah, I did that, oh yes, I did that. I mean at that time I mean you just loved to play an instrument so much you didn't care. But those were heavy. But you didn't care. You just put it on the train and you know, get down there and lug it up the stairs, and then you know my neighbors told me — we lived in the projects in New York City and of course everybody is very very close together. So my neighbor said the first time that I played a tuba in the apartment man they didn't know what was going on, they thought maybe an elephant had escaped, the sound was so horrendous. And my mother, she was just like, "Oh my God what is he doing?" Oh man. So she just ran in the room, "Are you okay?"

MR: "No, Mom, that's how it's supposed to sound."

JD: Yeah. But then, you know, I practiced every day. And my neighbors, because you know the neighbors in New York, they'll just start knocking on the wall. But my neighbors, they realized that, you know, they knew my family and they knew that I was trying to get someplace in life.

MR: This was a good pursuit for you.

JD: Yeah, this was a good pursuit. Yeah. So they didn't bother me. And after a while, you know, they began to enjoy what I was playing. Melodies were actually coming out. Things they could recognize.

MR: Did you have a moment or a period where you were going to decide to be a music educator or a music performer? Or was it the same?

JD: Well what happens is that I had people that were — like I told you when I got into Music and Art I had a mentor. And he also went on to Manhattan School of Music also. So I kind of followed him into Manhattan School of Music also. So what I was told is that music is a tremendous pursuit and everything, but just have a plan B. So Manhattan had an excellent program. Manhattan School of Music had an excellent program where you can go four years as a performing artist, like do your juries and everything, and pursue a career in music as a performer. But if you decided the fifth year, when you went into your master's program, the master's program had two ways you can come into it — as a performer or you can come in as a music educator. So if you came in as a music educator and you — you did one year — first of all they got you a job, they got you a job immediately, and then you worked toward your license during that year. So you would teach during the day and then you would come to Manhattan School of Music afterwards and take your classes into the evening and everything. And then you were making a salary, you had health benefits, you started your pension and all that stuff, you know. So everything started that way. So I was receiving a check from the Board of Education. It wasn't a lot of money, and I was finishing my studies at Manhattan School of Music, and I was working towards my teaching license. So when you graduated with your master's degree you had a master's in music education but you also got a New York City teacher's license and you also had a position, a job, which if you were doing well as a student teacher then they took you on to become the full time director. So the principal of that school liked what I was doing and took me on, and actually my wife at the time too, she was doing the same thing in vocal music. She was in vocal music and I was in — so she got a job teaching vocal music in the same school that I did doing instrumental music.

MR: I wonder if you had a moment like I had, and that was when you first get in front of that band and you're thinking okay here we go and all the kids are like looking at you or you're trying to get them quiet. I wonder what that was like for you.

JD: Oh yeah. Yeah, most definitely. What happens is that, as a beginning teacher, kids can sense when you're uncomfortable. And you've got to be uncomfortable the first time you get in front of a bunch of kids and everything. And you have them take out their instruments and everything, you know, it can be a very trying experience. But we were trained so well. We were trained how to start a student. The first thing we did was we kind of sectioned them off, you know, your woodwinds, your brass sections and everything. And then they started with just their mouthpiece. The trumpets, and the saxophones with the reeds and everything. The drummers would have pads instead of real drums and everything. So we started them off with that, and we did exercises with them just on fundamental things, getting a sound out of the thing. Because what happens with

mouthpiece, I mean there are buttons to press, this, the hole, then how do you get the mouthpiece in. It just becomes a frustrating thing. And then that's how a lot of band directors get kind of screwed around and have a very disruptive program. But the approach they taught us in Manhattan was start them with the mouthpiece and everything, and then maybe a week or two later then you get the instruments out. You show them — a lot of band directors didn't learn these techniques. You have to show the kid actually how to take the instrument out of the case and then when he takes it out of the case, where do you place the instrument. You show them where to place the instrument. Then how do you put the mouthpiece in. You don't bang it. Then you have to tell them one turn in, one turn out, one turn in, one turn out, one turn in. And then you have them put the instrument in and you start with the mouthpiece here, just getting that buzz, and then you slowly move the buzz into the instrument and everything. So once you learn those techniques, what you do is you, the kids are learning in a system — a step-wide approach to playing the instrument, and so their frustration level is very very low at that particular point. And they progress much more rapidly. So being trained to teach students how to play instruments — and then also I grew up in music programs, all the way from elementary school. So I saw what band directors did and everything. I wasn't just placed in front of a bunch of kids never having had that experience before in my life.

MR: Well it's quite a leap from that to the loft scene. And I wondered, as a tuba player, if you started listening to jazz, what did you think that your pathway into that music could be? Because you're not hearing a lot of tubas unless you're listening to New Orleans early, really early stuff, or I guess the opportunity presented by this new music.

JD: Yeah most definitely. So again, like mentors and stuff, people that you run into that change your life and change your course in history. So in New York City like I said, I grew up on the Latin, you know, New York scene, on the lower east side, which was a big Latin mecca. So I was playing — I had a valve trombone that I was doing gigs on on the Latin scene, playing valve trombones. And during the weekend the Latin scene, you can do a gig, an early gig starting around maybe eight, then you move to another venue and do a late night gig, and then you do an after-hours club until the next morning. Because that was before D.J.s and all that kind of thing. So every time you went into a club it was live music. Either Latin music or rhythm & blues. People came to dance to a real band. Unlike now when you come in and the guys are doing all kinds of stuff with the records and everything. So you can definitely work. So I worked a lot you know, but the concept of me playing tuba or anything in that context was like foreign to me because there was no other example. I didn't see any other tuba player playing in these bands. But then I ran into the great Howard Johnson. He was one of my — he kind of turned my

interesting things on the tuba. So he came in and he just like shattered my thoughts of what a tuba can do in a improvisational setting, or a setting where the music is not written down or structured and everything. Where I'm not playing a tuba part but I'm actually doing what the saxophones and everybody else is doing. I'm given the freedom to improvise and do all types of things. So Howard kind of reset my mind, and then I was also able to join his group at that time it was called Substructure. It was a group of six tubas and now it's called Gravity. So I was around other great tuba players that were improvising and everything. And then Howard, he was picking up so much work that he began to like okay I can no longer do this but I have somebody, you know, and then he would throw a recommendation to me. And then I'd come into the setting and everything and then when you come into a setting like following like an innovator, they expect you to be an innovator. So you couldn't come in following a great, great musician like that and be less than he was. Because they figure the reason you got the gig is because you can do what he did. And even though I couldn't do a lot of what he could do, I began to work and began to improvise and everything, and developed certain types of skills and everything. So I began to get calls from everybody that was on the scene that wanted a tuba. And most of the time they just wanted you to do whole notes and everything. And I learned this from Howard you know, when guys write for the tuba they kind of say okay, I'll give him a whole note here then give him a bunch of rests so he can get his breath then give him another whole note here. And then maybe give him — oh a half note. And maybe four quarter notes. And then I'll give him four eighth notes but they'll have to be scale wide [scats]. I mean very simplistic parts. But what Howard used to do, and what he taught us to do is that you know you play the guy's music first. And then you just quietly begin to add things to it. You know you add this, add this into it, and then you just look up at the guy and if he's looking at you and nodding then you begin to add more, add more, add more and everything. And this is what Howard did in the Gil Evans orchestra when he was working for Gil Evans. Because I actually played trombone with Howard sitting next to me. That's what he did. So Howard went in the Gil Evans orchestra. Gil would give him a fairly sophisticated part, but it was a tuba part, based on his writing for tuba and everything. So Howard would take that part and he would expand it. And then Gil heard it. And the next night when Howard came to the book, Gil had re-written the tuba part reflective of what Howard did. And so as Howard evolved the part, Gil evolved his writing for the tuba and realized that the tuba can do so much more. So then he began to write more and more for Howard and then Howard began to expand on that. So if you came in to sub for Howard Johnson in the Gil Evans orchestra — besides having lengthy, not an 8-bar tuba solo, I mean a full expressive tuba solo where you can just express

yourself and go as long as you want to play. Besides having that, your part was very very sophisticated you know and everything.

MR: How did that work with — the working with the bassist?

JD: Oh yeah that's the whole thing. In that band it was a bass player, his name was Herb Bushler. And him and Howard were like very good friends. And what Howard would do is he would listen to what Herb was playing on the bass, and he would pull out certain parts of what Herb was playing and incorporate those into the tuba part. So Howard was not only playing tuba parts, sectional parts, he was also playing tuba bass parts in conjunction with the bass player. And then at certain points he would say okay well rather than play with him, let's say if Herb is going up maybe if I go contrary down and go down and do that. So you know he would definitely work — that's the trick of the trade. You just can't play anything. You have to be listening to the people around you, what they do. And him and Herb became like a thing, where I mean if you listen to that album "Bengali" you listen to that and just listen to Howard Johnson and Herb Bushler on a piece called "Thoroughbred" written by Billy Harper. And just listen to how they interact and you see exactly what I mean with that. That's a prime example. I saw, because I was in the band at that time. In fact I'm on that record. I saw how Howard evolved with Herb from the time the arrangement came in until the time the arrangement was recorded. So you saw that evolution. And then Howard, you know, singlehandedly evolved the tuba, because then he passed it on to people like Bob Stewart, Dave Bargeron, Earl McIntyre, and a host of other people he passed this information on. And everybody that plays tuba now does that. Now it's just like expected of a tuba player and be able to play whatever's written and then listen to the bass player and when he has like open space you know, join the bass player and play in conjunction with the bass player and then if we have enough time to evolve to the point where you begin to do counter-lines against him, against what the bass is doing.

MR: Well Howard Johnson was like your graduate school.

JD: Oh yeah. He was my graduate school for jazz. Because jazz wasn't taught in Manhattan School of Music at that particular time. Jazz wasn't taught in my junior high school. Now my high school, we had a jazz program but it just had started. And I was fortunate enough to — in high school I never went to lunch. Because you know they had band classes all day. We had eight bands, we had eight orchestras, we had jazz ensemble, brass ensembles and everything. So any time there was a lunch period I would find where there was a band going on and I would sit in with that band or a brass ensemble, or I would find a practice room to practice. So I never ate lunch in the cafeteria. I practiced just about all the time. I have to get back to traveling. Because what happens is now is for me

transportation, food and budgets and everything. So it takes up so much time that you have to, it's difficult to get the amount of hours needed to be very very proficient on your instrument, the way I like to be. So I admit that I am slipping a bit right now, but that's because it's just the business of music is overwhelming. Because most musicians right now book themselves. I'm driving the van. You transport yourself and everything. It's like another thing about self-determination. You want the music to thrive and everything. If you don't do it, who's going to do it. So you have to begin to just do it and everything. And what most musicians are finding out — because if I tell an agent that, if I send him a CD of what I play and then I say I want to book a gig in Utica, New York, he'll say, "Nobody in Utica, New York wants to hear what you are playing." I mean because you heard it, it was very very progressive and everything. So they think there'd be no one in Utica that would want to hear anything like that you know. So what musicians are starting to find out is that audiences are a lot more sophisticated than a lot of agents are giving them credit for you know. They're very very sophisticated and they're very open to all kinds of music, all kinds of styles you know.

MR: I want to talk about that. You just used the word "progressive" to describe your own music, and over the years we've had the word free, free jazz, and avante garde. Do you object to any of those terms?

JD: Well avante garde means, you know, new, cutting edge. But this is music that has been played since 1971 you know. So I mean it's not new anymore. So avant garde is a term — just to put it in a box and everything. And free jazz, if you listen to Sam Rivers and other very sophisticated progressive players, they're not playing free. There's a lot of structure in what they're playing. And I don't play free. There's a lot of structure in what I play. I play it freely, but it's not just playing anything at any time I want to play. Like the whole concept of, you know I was talking to you about the bass and the tuba, you know, how Herb and Howard Johnson listened to each other and worked off of each other, that's what happens in this music, this progressive music. We work off of each other. I'm not just playing anything at any time and Warren is not just playing anything at any time. It's stuff that, you know that we're working to build ensemble experiences. So what we're doing is that we're spontaneously composing the music as we play it. And that's the thing that was interesting about Sam. Like we get on the stage, Sam Rivers, and we get on the stage and we wouldn't talk about anything but he'll begin to play. And at the end of the night, if you listen to everything that we played, there was form, there was structure you know. There was this, he would do this then there was maybe a transition, then we would change keys and then this and then we'd do another mood and then we'd go this. So at the end of the night when you listen to everything put together, you see the

The final structure comes after we completed composing the piece, as it would for any composer, whether they're Beethoven or Bach or Stravinsky. I mean their structure comes after the piece is completed.

MR: Say that again.

JD: Okay.

MR: Because I just had the wonderful opportunity to hear "The Rite of Spring" performed live, and I was thinking after I left last night that that came to mind. Because some of the stuff you did almost reminded me of parts of that piece, and I could envision Stravinsky writing all that complex music. You guys achieved the same feel with three people being spontaneous.

JD: Exactly. See that's the thing. I mean that's the thing about the whole new music, what they call the new music classical scene, you know. What happens is that for some strange reason, you know, like people like to divide people and put them in boxes and everything. No. If you go to a new music concert of ensemble concerts, you'll probably hear a lot of the things that we played, most definitely, yeah. But you know so if you go to a new music ensemble concert you'll hear a lot of the elements that we play on everything. But since we're improvising it, sometimes, the new music people sometimes look down, you guys are improvising it. Even though we're getting the same colors and textures and everything. Well the thing about "The Rite of Spring" that was interesting, of course you know they rioted after the concert, I think it was in Paris and everything. They tore the place down. It was like a blast from them — but what Stravinsky was, he tapped into African music, African rhythms and stuff, you know, those polyphonic rhythms. He tapped into it big time. Just like Picasso did he when got into the cubist movement and everything. He tapped into African art and everything. So he tapped into that, for the rhythmic structure of it all and everything. But what I was talking about is that when Stravinsky began to write the piece he had no idea where it would end. It's the same thing with the improvisation that we're talking about with Sam. When we start we have no idea where it's going to end. But when Stravinsky ends the piece then he looks back, he sees the structure of how many movements and stuff, and what this movement does and how this movement — it's the same thing with Sam. He starts off and he structures us and guides us through and then when we get to the end we look back and we see the structure, we see how we change keys, how we modulated, how we changed tempos, how we changed moods, how we changed textures, you know from going from the piano to the saxophone to the flute, and everything, a lot of the elements that I use in here, using different textures and colors and everything, and moving tempos along and moving textures and colors and yelling. The whole thing is what happens with a lot of musicians

that they're doing. Everything is just smooth and beautiful [scats]. And I mean it's beautiful and technically proficient but sometimes you got to yell out and scream you know. You just can't be talking in a conversational mode, even though it might be intellectually stimulating and beautiful and amazing technique and everything. Because sometimes you need to yell out and just go, "I need to scream." And that's what happens. You saw that with Scott. I mean Scott just, I mean you know how proficient and he can play — but sometimes he just wants to scream and he just screams in the saxophone and he just — and I think those things, because one woman said that she heard the music here last night. She said she heard the music, it just came up into her just like this you know. And it really affected her here. It wasn't here. She just felt the music right here. So sometimes you need to feel music in different places and everything. So those are important concepts that need to be addressed you know.

MR: I don't know if this is a silly question or not. But —

JD: There's no such thing as a silly question. I taught school for 30 years, every student. I said there's no such thing as a silly question.

MR: Well, do you, as a trio and in the other groups you've played in, do you avoid playing things that are much more obvious and associated with let's say less progressive music. For instance if Scott started playing a rhythm & blues type thing in a very particular key, would you join that or would you feel like I'm going to go another way with that, and then would Warren pick up that tempo?

JD: Oh yeah. Most definitely. I mean the thing is we don't abandon the history. Last night we did not do that. Because somebody else just mentioned the same thing. He said, "I was waiting for you guys to do a groove or something. You never did a groove." For some strange reason we never — I mean every night is different for us but yeah, but the night before actually we got into a really [scats]. Yeah we definitely do. Yeah. We don't, I mean you know if Scott starts playing "A Train" we'll jump right into "A Train" you know or whatever. I mean the thing is we don't abandon the tradition and everything. If we need to bring it out and use it, or the trio moves into that, but definitely not at least me, and all the musicians that I know that play so-called free jazz or avante garde jazz, we're not anti-tradition. And if tradition comes into what we're doing, we're not going to just push it aside just to be different. It's not about that. It's about extending the tradition into what we're doing and everything. And I mean because Sam, Sam Rivers played with Miles Davis, he played with Dizzy Gillespie, and he knew all the standards, he knew all the tunes and everything.

MR: Well it's not that much different than the transition from swing music into bop then. Those guys were expanding the tradition.

JD: Right. That's exactly what has happened. And you know, bop was, people said bop wasn't, I mean here, the description they gave for bop, bop wasn't for dancing, well that's not true. I mean if you see the people doing the lindy hop and all that stuff, you know, at those very fast tempos, you know, so people danced to bop just like they did to swing. It's just that swing was, the tempos of swing were not as fast as the tempos for bop. So you had to have some serious dancing skill to dance to bebop, whereas dancing to swing, you could just get your partner and just go back and forth. It's a different tradition and a different generation, a generational thing. But dancing was definitely part of things that you could do with bop, and there's dancing in the stuff that we do, you can definitely dance to it too, once we get down a groove and everything. And if you go to a thing like the Vision Festival you'll see like Patricia Parker dancing to all kinds of avante garde, so-called avante garde music and everything. So you can dance to everything. And like I said, we just extended the tradition. We're not abandoning it and we love Duke Ellington and Thelonious Monk and all those great musicians just as much as the people that play the tradition also.

MR: I was talking with Warren yesterday a bit about Max Roach.

JD: Oh Max, okay, yes.

MR: He had a political content to his music at times. And I wonder if you guys, if you feel any of your music has a political message.

JD: All of our music has a political message. The thing is this: as African-American, especially African-American men, there's always a message that we can do and we can survive. Because I can just leave here and go driving down across the Thruway and then you know get pulled over by a police officer and the next morning you read that I've been shot. And a lot of people won't even bat their eye, because it's just, this type of thing just happens. So the injustices that have been put on us as African-Americans, you know, by this society and everything, every time we play we're making some type of political statement you know. Especially like the second set — the music, I call it the revolution— this is revolutionary music and everything. And every ensemble, one of the CDs I had out last night was the "Trayvon Martin Suite" thing that I did with Bill Cole and everything. We have political — my "Seven Deadly Sins" has a huge track that I wrote for my brother called "Ballad of the Fallen African Warrior" you know dealing with his demise via the healthcare system in America. So the music has, everything that I do has a political — sometimes I don't think it's appropriate, like last night I didn't think it was appropriate to address that in certain situations. But yeah, but everything that I do has to have a political statement you know, because you know, I'm a reflection of society and everything. And you know, I've got to let people know that my life matters too. Like

people are failing to understand is because I say that Black Lives Matter, it doesn't mean that other people's lives do not matter, but they're already protected in the system. You know, they're not going to be shot down like Trayvon Martin for no reason or anything. They have these protections built in already. So people know their lives matter and they treat them with that type of respect. But for some strange reason, people, especially law enforcement and other people, think that our lives do not matter. So we're not — Black Lives Matter is an inclusive movement. We're including, you know we include everybody in the concept of Black Lives Matter. Because we already know that people know that these other lives matter so we just want that same type of respect. So it's just a matter of getting the same type of respect as the other people whose lives, based on the way society is set up, their lives already matter. So we just want that same type of respect.

MR: Wow. Thanks for sharing that. What do you say when someone says, "Yeah but things are much better than they used to be"?

JD: Well for some and everything. But you know if you look at the data of fallen African-American men and women, through no fault, they haven't done anything. I mean I think the numbers are still pretty high and everything and all. So the thing is, things can be seen as better because we have Oprah Winfrey and these other people that have done very well for themselves and everything. But there was a very interesting report, I don't know if you saw that, coming out of Boston, that says like the average white family in Boston has assets of about 240, around the two hundred thousand range and everything. And the African-American and Hispanic, theirs is zero to below zero of money in relationship to debt and income you know. So the amount of money that they have coming in to cover their expenses just covers their expenses. Sometimes it may not. So if you look at their total resources in relationship to debt and income, you know, they are in the minus column you know, or at zero. So when you look at those numbers you say well things are better for some and things are, even though they seem to be better for others are not really that much better. But a lot of people don't look at data. They just turn on the television and turn to their favorite station and have that poor person just pour on all the information of what they want to hear. They don't want to hear the other things. I mean it's evident. Because if you talk to someone about the president, you say well the president is, well he's done X, he's done Y, he's done Z, he's done that you know. We don't care. We don't care what he's done. We don't care. I mean even women. Women say we don't care he's a this and we don't care he's a that, we just don't care. So I mean what do you do in that type of circumstance, when you present information and data to a person, and facts and everything, and they say they don't care. I mean just like the whole thing about

Obama being born in Kenya. I mean the data is there to say that, but then they say that almost 30% of the population still thinks that he was born in Kenya and he's a Muslim.

MR: Yeah it's scary. You'd think that the instant communication that we have now would make things better and more truthful and it's not.

JD: But the thing is people don't want to hear it. It's almost like saying to the coal miners that believe those jobs are coming back — if they do come back, they're going to come back with robots. They're not coming back, they're not sending human beings down into those mines anymore. And the whole concept, what Obama was trying to do, he was putting in programs where he had community college programs where these people come and be re-trained for real jobs that were coming in the future. And they rejected that. My father was a coal miner, my grandfather was a coal miner, I'm going to be a coal miner. Yeah you're going to be a coal miner but there's no coal miner jobs so you're going to be a coal miner sitting around with your hat and light on for the rest of your life you know. So these guys rejected re-training for the dream and the fallacy that our new president has put forth saying, "I'm bring these jobs back." Because he has no idea of the complexity. I mean life is not very very as simple, there's complex layers and layers and layers of things that need to be taken care of. Life is not simple. And the only way you know about complexity is that you've got to do a lot of reading, you've got to study, and you just can't watch one station. You've got to go across the gamut, you have to read different papers because different papers have different information. And you have to travel internationally, which most Americans, they say most Americans don't even have a passport. If you're not traveling internationally and you're talking about people in Muslim countries and you've never been to a Muslin country in your life, they you've got an issue there. That's a serious problem you know. I mean how could you talk about these people being this and being that, if you've never been there. And then this whole thing where women and men come into a restaurant and someone's speaking in their native tongue and they turn around and say, "Stop that! You're an American now, speak English." And I mean how ridiculous. I mean that's one of the things I love, you know, when you're traveling internationally and you go to the airport. And you have people, you know, surrounding you, all of them speaking different languages, all the different rhythms, all the different tones and all the nuances and everything. I think that is so beautiful when you have people surrounding you speaking different languages. Even if you don't understand what they're saying, just the tones. I guess maybe that's being a musician, but I've found that with other people too. You know I just like it when somebody's speaking German, somebody's speaking in French, somebody's speaking in Spanish, all simultaneously. And you know just those rhythms are just delightful. I love

MR: Well I can hear that, now that you say that, I can hear that coming out in your music.

JD: Yeah, that too.

MR: I wanted to get to something, before we wrap up. I took advantage last night, because your music was on the stand, and when you went on break I went up and I was looking at it.

JD: You're welcome to do that anytime.

MR: You've got the ovals —

JD: Right.

MR: With a graph of a sort. And is that sort of your blueprint so to speak? And at first I just thought that was interesting. And then coupled with a composed melody that you and Scott eventually would join together on. And I just wanted to comment on that. I thought that was interesting. You sort of invented a way to get your ideas across.

JD: Yeah. Well I didn't invent that. I mean the graphic scores have been used for years and years and years. Graphic scores are basically an eye concept that many musicians — I mean going back to like Mingus, instead of having an icon like Mingus would just draw a casket and say pass it on. This is what I want. I want you guys to sound like this. And it would be like a casket, you know, something that would kind of like push you into another emotional level. Because the concept in music is to get off of the page. You know what I mean is that you don't want to sound to the audience like you're reading the notes on the page. You want to get the notes off the page and assimilate that into your psyche and into your emotional being and then express that as an emotional entity. Not just playing notes off a page and everything. And sometimes in order to get musicians to do that you have to kind of like kick them in the butt, I mean like but Mingus would do that physically too. I mean he would just knock them down if he needed to. So he would do it on that level if it needed to be done that way. But other times he would just draw an image or he would make a political statement, or he was just, you know he was a big, robust, so he would just bully the musician into a position where the musician wanted to fight Mingus back, but you know he couldn't fight him back physically but he was fighting back via the sounds he was getting out of his instrument and everything. So that's the way you get to the next level of expression in the music and everything, where people are not expressing you know like C and D and F and everything, they're expressing emotional sounds and stimulants through each note. And what that graphic score does, it gives the musicians like an outline of who is doing what and everything, and then moving into the melody that I want to use is that rather than just write the melody out without the musicians seeing exactly who is doing what, where, when, with the graphic score. And a prime example of how a graphic score is used is if you see a

band. They plot them out through the graphic score like that where this person's at the 15 yard line, then he goes this and then he goes up. And this icon comes around and it forms this beautiful whatever, this formation. So the same type of thing with me. I take these icons and I move them along, and then I want a certain textorial formation set up. And the musician sees the exact texture that I want set up. And I want these textures to introduce the next segment of the music that we're doing, and then part of that introduction to the next segment is going to eventually lead us into a point where we're going to play a melodic line, based on the textorial distribution of how the instruments are set in place, like I was talking to you last night about how the tuba and the bass saxophone complement each other, the baritone sax and the tenor saxophone complement each other. So that visualization of that, and then it also alerts the musician who will listen for it. Okay I've got to listen to him, I've got to listen, or whatever. And then there's certain things in that graphic thing that says who sets the tempo. Who's going to be the lead voice and everything. And some of the colors, I tell the musicians that if you have to color, if your color is this color then you're the lead person here. If your color is this then you're background and everything. So there's a lot of things in the color concept of a graphic score. But it's not a new concept and a lot of classical ensembles are using it also, in different sorts of ways. It's just a new way to notate music so that the musician can get off of the page a lot quicker and get into deeper emotional outbursts of sound than they would just reading C on the third space or whatever.

MR: I had an interesting thing yesterday because I got to ask Warren how do you as a trio know when to end some of these spontaneous compositions. And then I got to see it last night, and hear it, that it sort of made sense. I can't tell you why but it sounded like, I mean no one did a cut-off but it was sort of like —

JD: If anybody does a cut-off we're not going to look anyway. No the thing is it's just like I'm talking to you and you're talking to me. That's the thing about, we're talking to each other. You know when the conversation's over you're not going to cut me off and say the conversation's over. The conversation just naturally just comes to an end. We talked about certain things and you will make a statement saying, you know, okay well thank you very much, and then I know automatically, oh it's coming to an end. Well the same type of thing, you know, Warren will do something or Scott will do something or I'll do something and then we'll know, because you know last night, I don't know if you — I'm going to talk to Scott about this tonight, I mean when we were driving in. But somebody told him that we had to end at a certain time.

MR: Right.

JD: And I heard in his playing that he was trying to make the ensemble stop. I heard it him

I didn't want to stop. That's what I'm saying. Sometimes you have these conflicts. I didn't want to stop because he told us that we could go —

MR: Orin said.

JD: Yeah Orin said, he told me we could go to 11, and then Scott heard, somebody told Scott that we had to stop at 10:30. So Scott was trying to stop us at 10:30 and then his wife said well why don't we just go to quarter to 11. She split the difference. So I was working towards, well I figured I didn't want to go to quarter to 11, I wanted to go to ten to 11, but Scott wanted to stop at 10:30. And I kept hearing for him pushing. Well that's what I'm saying. I mean each musician can push us to stop. And they push us to go. They can push us to go out, they can push us to go in. They can push us to be sensitive, they can push us to be hard, they can push us to be harsh you know, depending on what they do. Because we feed off each other. We feed off each other. So if I hear Warren really pushing then I know I've got to push you know. If I hear him backing off then I know I can back off and everything. Same thing with Scott. So that's the interaction of music just like we're interacting right now. You know if I say something funny, you know you'll have to make a determination whether you're going to laugh or not, right. But it's the same type of thing, you know, because if I say something to insult you then all of a sudden it's a whole different reaction. So it's the same type of thing here. That's the thing about the power of improvised music is that it builds the brain in a different sort of way. Because at the same time, because you have the skill, I can see it, you have the skill to listen and speak at the same time. A lot of people don't have that you know. Once they start talking their ears shut down. And that's the whole thing about playing music. As you're playing you have to listen to what's going on around you because if you don't then why are you playing and who are you playing with? And I know, I blame some bands and musicians, when they tell me that when they sing their part they don't hear, or they play it, they don't hear it. I say how could you exist on the stage like that, where you don't hear what's going on with the rest of the band. All you just concentrate on what you are doing. I said how could you exist like that. I mean but you end up finding out that those musicians are very, very rigid. Because the band begins to bend and begins to do different things and these people don't, they just like — my part — they're just driving their part along even though the band might slow down or whatever, they don't slow down. They just drive their thing. And it's harsh. It's very very harsh. It's a very very harsh reality. But some people don't have that skill where they can listen and talk at the same time, or they can play and listen to what the other musicians are playing and assimilate a change when that person changes and then you make a change at the same time, not based on visual cues or anything, just based on a person hearing that okay this person made a change, he's going faster, he's

and everything. And that's what I love about this ensemble. We have the ability to do that type of thing where we can change on a dime based on input from any one of us. And then if we expand the ensemble and get other musicians of the same type of sensitivity, they will have the same inputs.

MR: Well I have to say it's been a very inspiring conversation.

JD: Yeah well thank you very much.

MR: So logistically we have to get you, you've got, I wonder if you have a roadie coming in for all this stuff.

JD: No, no.

MR: That's a luxury that none of us can afford.

JD: Not this — well you know you have to build a career and a base and everything. So coming up here, this was really my first time, me and the group coming through this area and everything. But next time I come a lot of this stuff could be rented by venues. Like we're going to New Mexico in a week or so and of course they know we can't bring this stuff so they're making arrangements to have all this stuff there for us and rented and everything. But right now, sometimes you have to get in the door first, and then when you get in the door you can say okay listen, we came here, we brought all this equipment up and everything, now if you want us back you're going to have to make arrangements to either go by the local college — most colleges, you go by them you know and then talk to the band director and everything. He'll let you use their equipment for the evening, especially if you give a donation to the school for a minimal thing.

MR: Well I want to thank you for sharing your wisdom with me.

JD: Yeah well thank you. You know as you get older and older and older you become wiser and wiser and wiser you know, mainly because you've had the experience of being around all the older people, and older people, they impart so much knowledge on you and a lot of that stuff you don't get when you're young. But as you get older and older those things kind of like stick into your psyche and then all of a sudden you're saying okay, now I know why that person said this, why that person said that. All those things. Things that kind of just like went over your head when you were young and everything.

MR: Great. Best of luck to you.

JD: Oh yeah best of luck to you and congratulations, and I hope you continue doing this for many many more decades.

MR: Likewise. Over and out.

JD: Over and out.